therefore, India's foreign policy became 'a search for power' and not for moral influence.[83]

A key part of building India's military strength and security was the nuclear dimension. Indira maintained the dual policy of Nehru with respect to championing disarmament while continuing to build India's nuclear potential. It was under Indira that India undertook its first nuclear test in 1974 and despite condemnation and threat of sanctions Indira continued with India's nuclear weapons programme. She saw it as the natural course for India as both its adversarial neighbours, China and Pakistan, were also building their nuclear weapons programmes.

The desire for an independent foreign policy remained strong under Indira as it did under Nehru. For her it meant both India's territorial integrity as well as economic autarky. A constant refrain in her pronouncements was that while India was 'politically free' but economic and technological dependence on other countries meant that it did not enjoy 'complete freedom'. She said, 'My idea of freedom is a self-reliant nation. It is true no nation today can be fully self-reliant. We shall have to have something from outside; but at least there should be a base of self-sufficiency and self-reliance.'[84] Her economic and security policies tied in to her particular take on non-alignment as well.

For Indira, non-alignment was not simply 'avoidance of entanglement' with the two blocs but rather 'preserving independence despite close relations with one or both of them.'[85] While India under Indira continued to champion non-alignment, Indira sought to narrow its focus more in terms of the interests of the developing countries. Under Indira's leadership, there was a growing 'insistence on autonomy' which was in sharp contrast to the reality – India's need for economic and military aid. The reduction or elimination of direct US aid was seen as 'a badge of honour'. Hence for Indira, deeper ties with the Soviet Union and even the 1971 treaty of friendship with the Soviets (concluded amidst US backing for Pakistan